“Setting boundaries is selfish.”

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Where it often comes from

Many believers were taught to be selfless, to turn the other cheek, and to put others first. Those are good teachings, but they can be bent into the idea that having any limits is sinful. People who grew up caring for a troubled parent or sibling may have been told that their needs did not matter.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus “frequently withdrew to the wilderness to pray,” and He did not heal everyone in every town. Proverbs says, “Guard your heart with all diligence, for from it flow springs of life,” and “Like a city whose walls are broken down is a man who does not control his temper.” Paul writes, “Each one should carry his own load.” Jesus said the second greatest commandment is to love your neighbor as yourself, which assumes some care for yourself. Boundaries are not walls to keep love out. They are fences that protect what is valuable, including your ability to love others well.

> *“Yet He frequently withdrew to the wilderness to pray”* (Luke 5:16).

Also see

> “Early in the morning, while it was still dark, Jesus got up and slipped out to a solitary place to pray” (Mark 1:35).
>
> “Guard your heart with all diligence, for from it flow springs of life” (Proverbs 4:23).
>
> “Like a city whose walls are broken down is a man who does not control his temper” (Proverbs 25:28).
>
> “For each one should carry his own load” (Galatians 6:5).

Common self-statements

- Good Christians have no limits.
- Saying no is putting myself first.
- Selfless people never say no.
- I should always be available.
- Limits are unloving.
- My needs do not count.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either selfless or selfish.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should always be available.
- Labeling: Calling myself selfish for having limits.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that boundaries are wrong.

Challenging questions

- Where did I learn that limits are selfish?
- Did Jesus ever step away or say no?
- What happens to my love and patience when I have no limits?
- What is the difference between selfish and healthy?

- What boundary would help me love better?
- Who would benefit if I were rested and well?

Truth summary

> Boundaries are a way to steward my time, energy, and heart so I can love well. Jesus Himself withdrew to rest and pray. Healthy limits are not selfish. They help me serve without resentment.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Wisdom
- Self-Sacrifice
- Tired
- Love, For Others
- Temptation

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Weak/Tired
- Communication

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Oh My Soul — Casting Crowns
Honest distress can coexist with faith and hope in God.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "Setting boundaries is selfish"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Setting boundaries is selfish." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Where did I learn limits are selfish?
- ☐ What did Jesus do?
- ☐ What limit do I need?
- ☐ How will I say it?
- ☐ What will it allow?
- ☐ Who benefits?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Jesus withdrew to pray.
- ☐ I am to guard my heart.
- ☐ Boundaries protect love.
- ☐ I carry my own load.
- ☐ Self-control is a virtue.
- ☐ Healthy limits help me serve.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Luke 5:16
  "Yet He frequently withdrew to the wilderness to pray."
- ☐ Proverbs 4:23
  "Guard your heart with all diligence, for from it flow springs of life."
- ☐ Galatians 6:5
  "For each one should carry his own load."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ A limit that helped: Each week, record a boundary you kept and what it allowed.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Luke 5:16 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Jesus withdrew to pray, so I can set healthy limits.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Self-Sacrifice" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Define a boundary. Write one limit you need.
- ☐ Communicate it kindly. Explain it simply, without a long defense.
- ☐ Hold it gently. Repeat it calmly if tested.
- ☐ Rest and pray. Take time alone like Jesus did.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Setting boundaries is selfish": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A limit that helped
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Setting boundaries is selfish.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord Jesus, You withdrew to be with the Father. Teach me to guard my heart, set loving limits, and serve without resentment. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.